at Natu La, which was a border pass on the Sikkim-Tibet frontier.

None of these ideas were new or original. Before the boundary conflict occurred in 1962, trade between Sikkim and the Chumbi Valley in Tibet had been a regular activity since the early 1900s; mail was being exchanged at Natu La; and the two armies had continued to maintain an informal liaison on the Tibet-Sikkim frontier all through the freeze in diplomatic relations after 1962. None of these had meant that China recognized Sikkim as a State of India. In 1996, Chinese Foreign Minister Qian Qichen offered the idea to Foreign Minister I.K. Gujral that the re-opening of trade would be tantamount to an acknowledgement of the status quo by China. [16] It was a persuasive argument, and might have even sounded reasonable were it not for India's experience over a similar matter in the 1950s. The 1954 Trade Agreement between India and the Tibet Region of China had, similarly, identified six border passes in the Middle Sector through which trade and other intercourse could take place between the Tibet region of China and India. India had assumed that this was tantamount to a recognition of where our boundary lay. The Chinese first kept their counsel, then dissimulated when pressed and finally said that the boundary had not been a subject for discussion at the time, and that the six passes named in the 1954 agreement were only a specific modality for a specific purpose—namely trade. Now, forty years later, the Chinese were offering up the same formula for Sikkim.

The Chinese case was that the 'process' of recognition had to be gradual, tantalizingly suggesting that a trade arrangement might be the first step, and thus subtly mounting pressure on the Indian side to be flexible and to not insist that the Chinese side bring a solution once and for all. The Chinese duplicity in 1954 was, however, seared into the mind of every diplomat who